recalcitrant, orthodox Sunni as it was later believed. Then Badauni asked for five months leave, ‘on account of certain important affairs, or rather follies’, and during that time, tragically, Badauni’s son died. Badauni would hold the emperor responsible for this dreadful calamity and would not return to court for a whole year. For Akbar, this was an unpardonable lapse in duty in a courtier and Badauni acknowledged this saying the Padshah ‘took no further notice of me’. From here on, despair in his heart, Badauni could only watch as his old schoolmate, Abu’l Fazl, climbed inexorably through the ranks at court while he languished, ignored and ridiculed.

After their sojourn in the Punjab, Akbar and the court returned to Fatehpur Sikri where Faizi, who had by now been honoured with the title ‘King of Poets’, greeted the Padshah with a charming couplet:

The breeze that cheers the heart comes from Fathpur
For my King returns from a distant journey

In Fatehpur Sikri the ulema seemed not to have anticipated the undercurrents rippling below the smooth sandstone pathways of the palaces and courtyards. They had perhaps not understood that for the Timurids, the Islamic sharia was never as binding a force as it was in other Islamic kingdoms and that there remained the companionable presence of Chenghiz Khan’s yassa laws, and their pre-Islamic guiding spirits. The yassa advised the ruler ‘to consider all sects as one and not to distinguish one from another’. Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi raged that ‘every evil that appeared in those days…was due to the wickedness of these evil ulema who have been a menace to mankind and to the word of God’. Abd un-Nabi especially, because of Akbar’s earlier devotion and his own obdurate arrogance, was about to make a grave error of judgement.

The qazi of Mathura came to the sadr with a complaint one day because some materials that he had gathered in Mathura for the construction of a mosque had been forcibly requisitioned by a Brahmin and used to build a temple. When the qazi had protested, the Brahmin had used offensive language against Prophet Muhammad. Akbar sent Abu’l Fazl and Birbal to investigate the matter and they found that the blasphemy had, indeed, been uttered. With the Brahmin taken into custody, the matter of the punishment to be given to the offender was debated. ‘The ladies of the imperial harem busied themselves in interceding for his release,’ we are told, and we can well imagine Harkha Bai of Kachhwaha, with her clan connection to the temples of Mathura, using her influence to free the Brahmin. Akbar,